by one analyst as a sign ‘that old turf and territories may no longer be sacrosanct’.[38]

Notwithstanding the changes in the foreign office’s organization at various times, the training of civil servants remains as stringent as it was under colonial days. In case of the Indian Foreign Service, Bandyopadhyaya points out, well trained professional diplomats are crucial for India’s international relations. ‘However rational the broad goals and principles of foreign policy determined by the political executive may be,’ he writes, ‘there will be a wide gap between theory and practice if the personnel responsible for the various major aspects of policy are not properly selected, trained and utilized.’[39] Since 1926, recruitment of India’s civil servants has taken place through the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) – formerly Federal Public Service Commission – an independent body that conducts annual examinations for recruitment for various Indian administrative services, including the Indian Foreign Service and the Indian Administrative Service (IAS).

Once selected, new recruits (or probationers as they are called) train first along with colleagues from other services at the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration in Mussourie before heading to the Foreign Service Institute (FSI) in Delhi for specialized training. The training period lasts for three years after which each officer is assigned a compulsory foreign language. After a brief attachment to the Ministry of External Affairs in New Delhi, the young IFS officer is posted to an Indian mission based on language skills. At the end of the three-year training period, officers must pass an examination before being allowed to continue further in the service.

British India had no embassies but at the end of World War II, two offices of agent general were set up, one in the US and one in China, whose duties were limited to consular affairs including issuance of visas. After 1947, India’s international presence grew rapidly and by 1953 India had opened